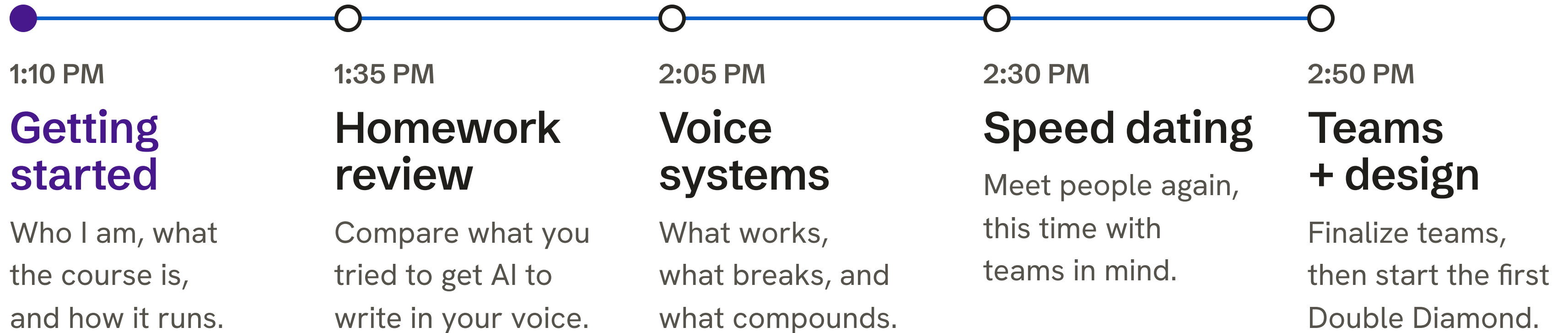


Startup Studio

Teams, voice, and the next design move

Class 2 · Friday, September 18, 2026 · 1:10 to 3:40 PM · Pupin 420

What we're doing today



Instructor Intro

We have TAs!

Instructor intro

Two talented people who have taken the course.

TA

Shrey Kumar Arora

ska2153@columbia.edu

TA

Maanas Karthike Senthil Kumar

ms7492@columbia.edu

Who am I?

Instructor Intro

Ken St. Clair

- Early-stage start-up Product Leader with 20+ years experience
 - Software engineering, sales engineering, product design, product leadership
 - Two robotics products from 0→1
 - Experience with 0→1, growth, acquisition, and deprecation
 - B2B, B2B2C, B2C
- BS Computer Science, Georgia Tech
- Masters of Human-Computer Interaction, Carnegie Mellon



aescape



Carnegie
Mellon
University



Georgia Institute
of Technology

Whom have I Worked with?

Instructor Intro

Select Partners and Clients

Gyms + Spas

EQUINOX

LIFETIME
HEALTHY WAY OF LIFE

LOTTE NEW YORK PALACE

REMEDY PL

THE WELL

Print Media

The New York Times

Bloomberg

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

The Atlantic

THE HUFFINGTON POST

VICE

Broadcast

Turner

Disney

ESPN

NBC

VIACOM

CBS

Streaming/Sports

MLG
MAJOR LEAGUE GAMING

twitch

ROKU

NHL

NFL

Food Service

OUTBACK STEAKHOUSE®

White Castle

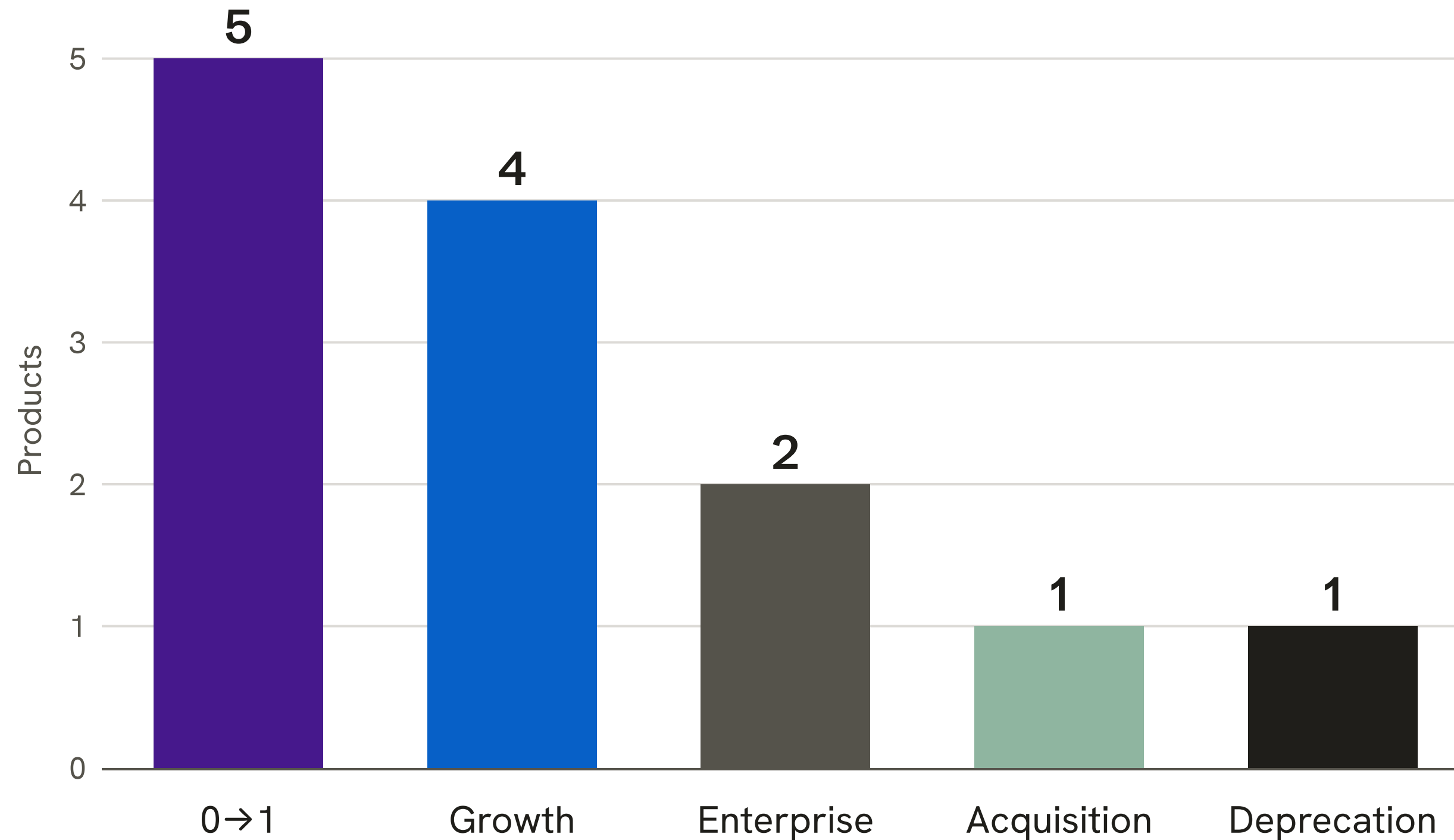
More...

tinder

Nationwide

Product Stages I've Worked On

Instructor Intro



Class Intro

What's a “Studio”

A course focused on **making**, **iterating**, and **critique**.

Students learn by building real artifacts and receiving continuous feedback, rather than by absorbing theory first.



What's “Startup Studio”

A course focused on **making, iterating, critique, experimentation and launching.**

Students learn by building real artifacts and receiving continuous feedback, rather than by absorbing theory first.



Three pillars of the course

Agentic engineering

Using AI tools to rapidly build software that is reliable and secure.

UX techniques

Methods for advancing product-market fit, including user interviews and usability testing.

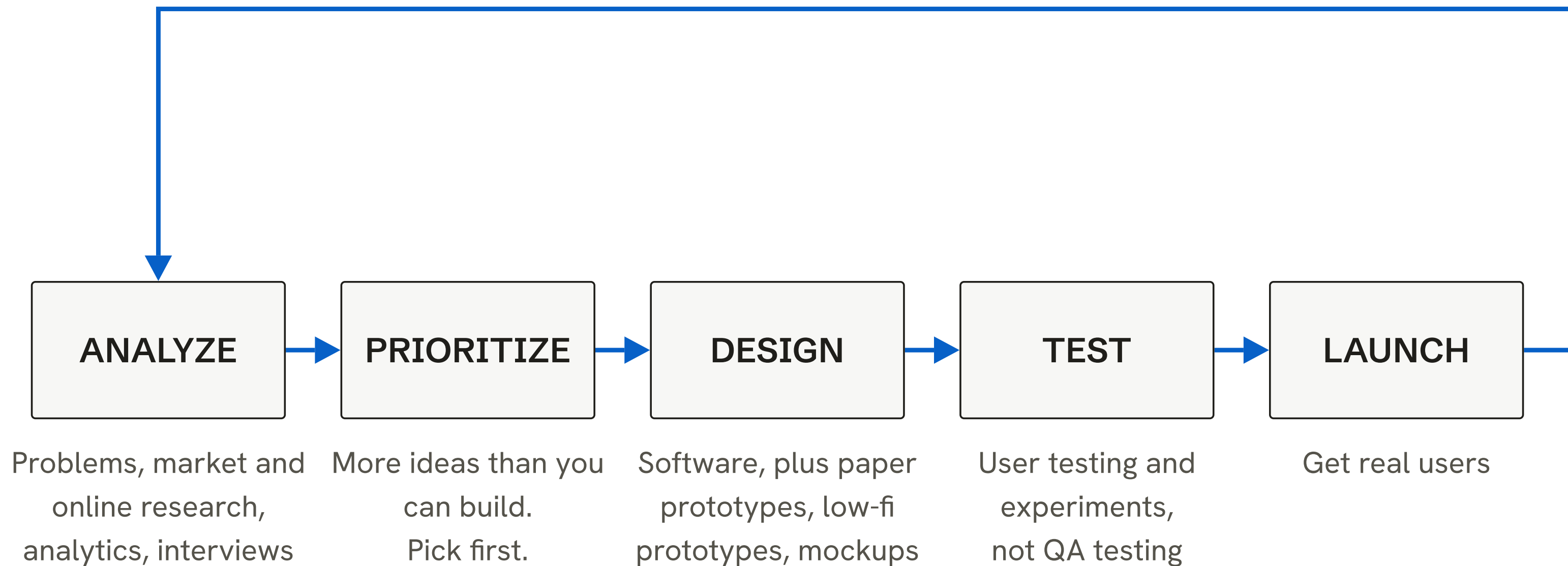
Startup knowledge

Growth hacking, presentation skills, fundraising, and how founders operate.

Startup OS

Class Intro

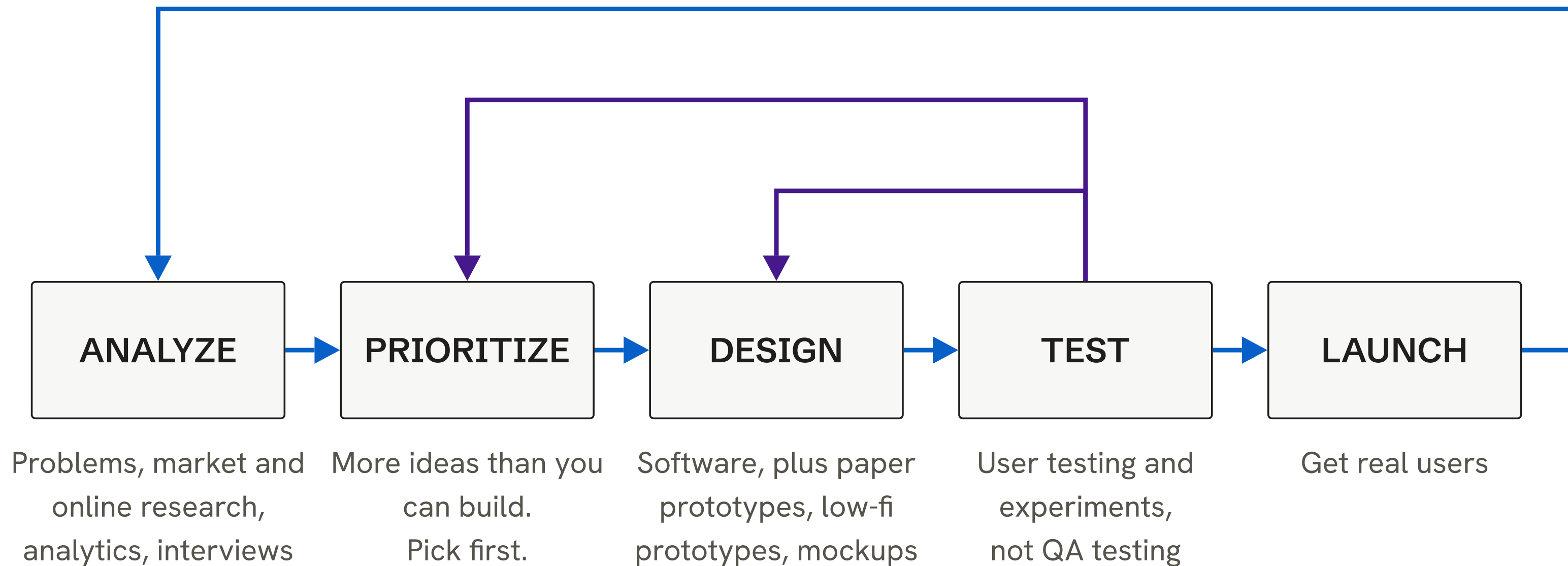
The operating system for this class



Startup OS

Class Intro

The operating system for this class



Analyze

Class Intro

- Problem Exploration
- Market research
- Online research
- Monitoring analytics
- User interviews

Prioritize

Class Intro

- I've got more ideas than I can execute at once
- How do I pick which to do first?

Design(/Build)

Class Intro

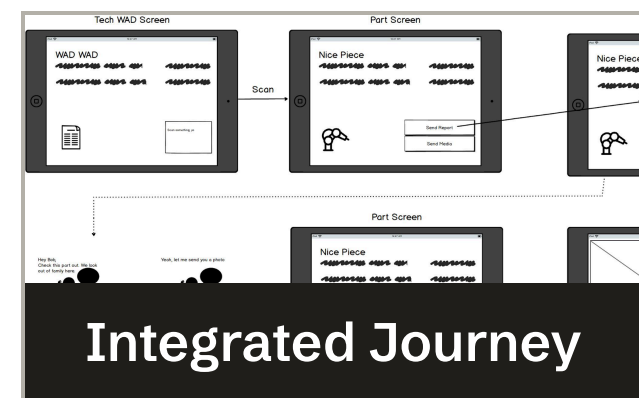
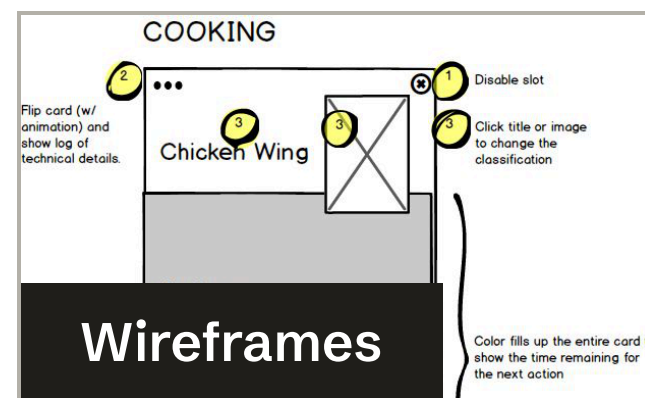
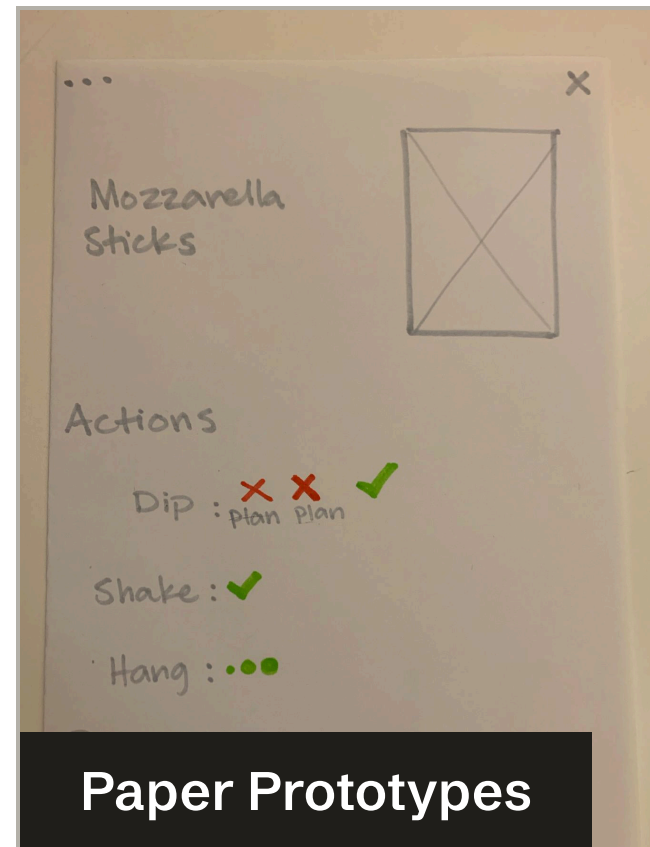
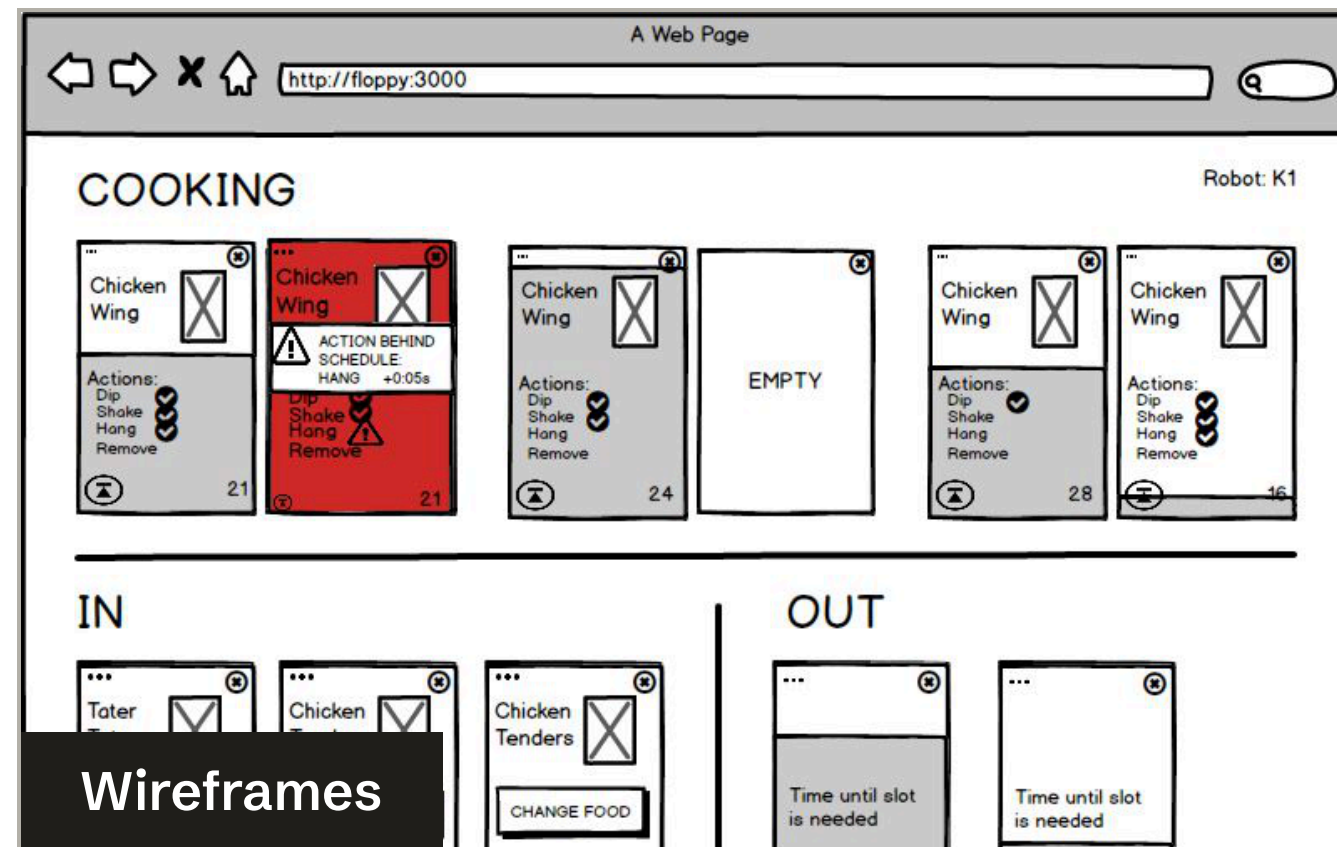
- Software, yes

But building also includes

- Paper prototypes
- Low-fi prototypes
- Mockups

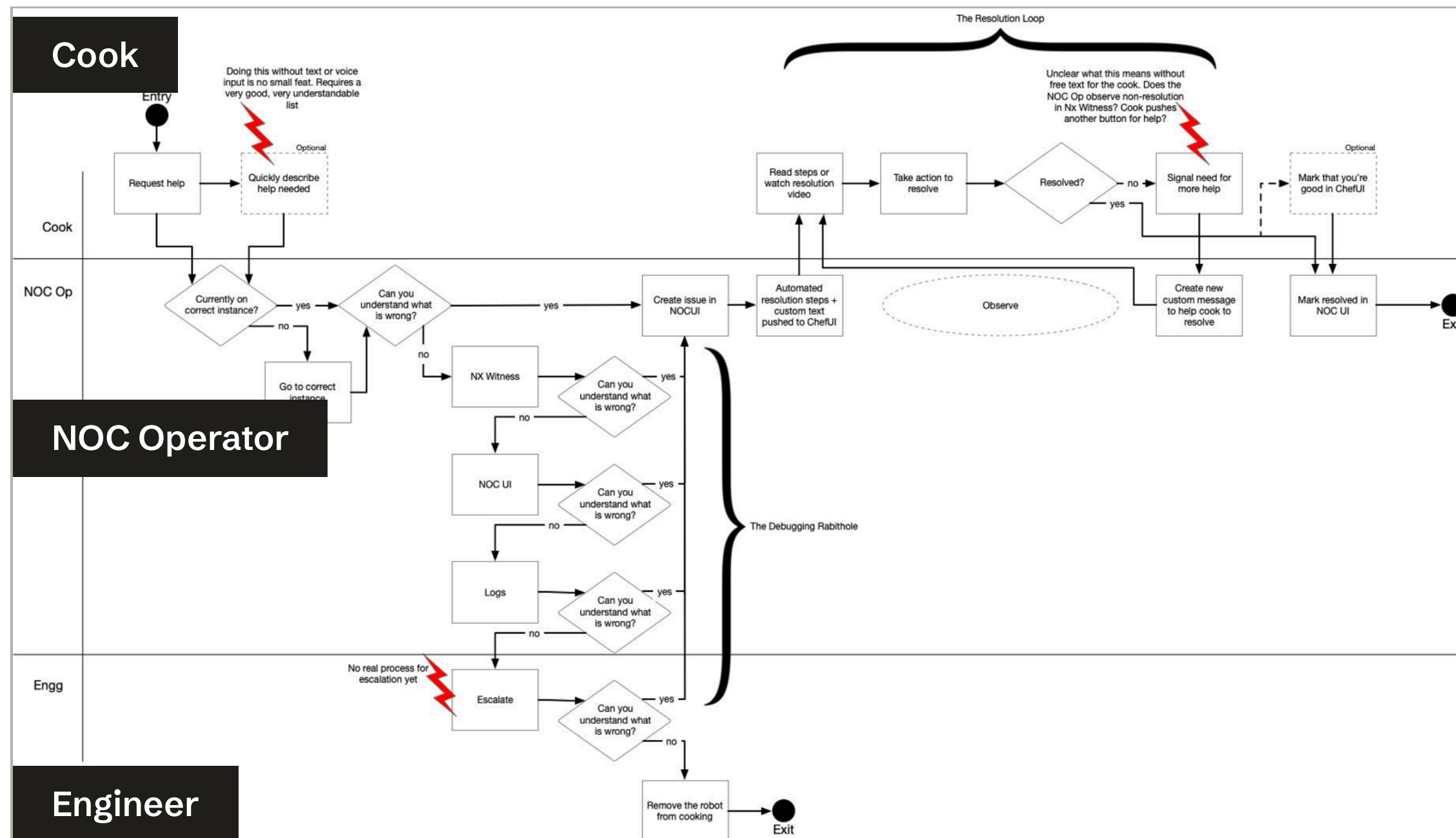
[Design Ex.] Personas, Wireframing, Integrated Journeys

Class Intro



[Design Ex.] The Debugging Rabbit Hole and Resolution Loop

Class Intro



Mapping the debugging process across each user – Cook, NOC Operator, and Engineer – allowed us to identify high impact areas of focus: the debugging rabbit hole, and the resolution communication loop.

Improved performance and efficiency in debug and resolution have a direct impact on revenue by affecting the throughput and overall volume of the cooking session.

Test

Class Intro

Not QA testing

- User Testing
- Experiments

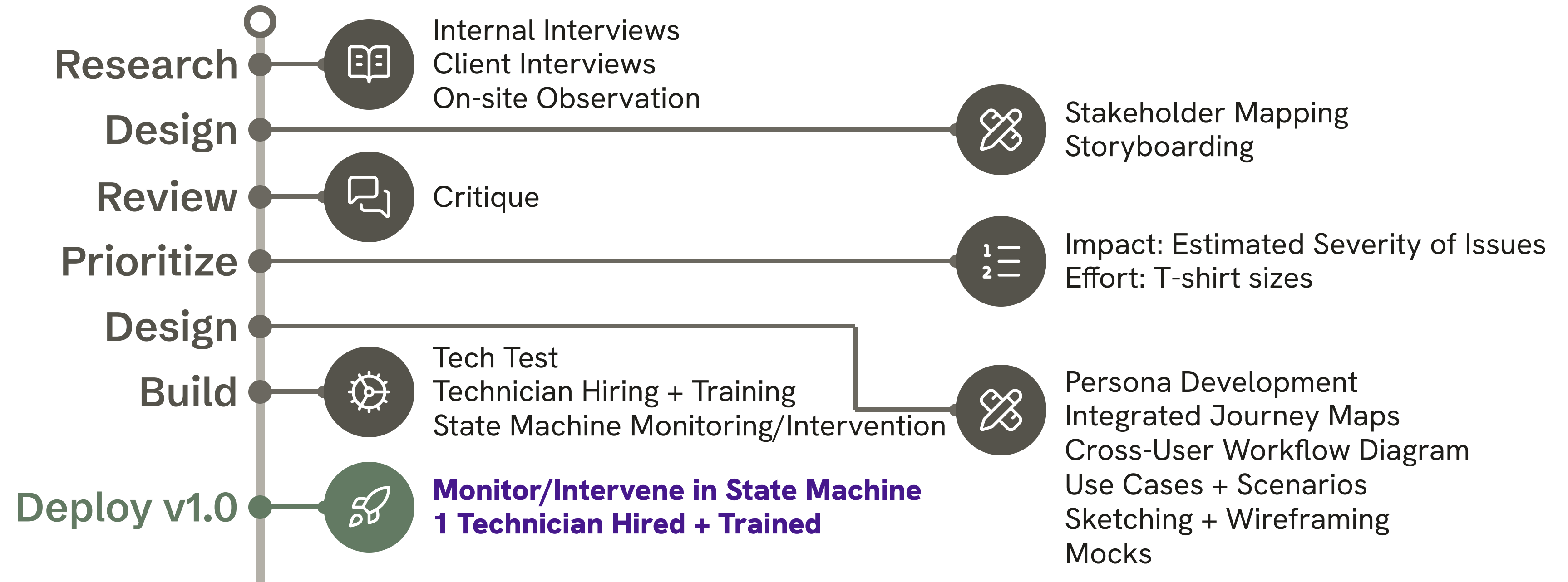
Launch

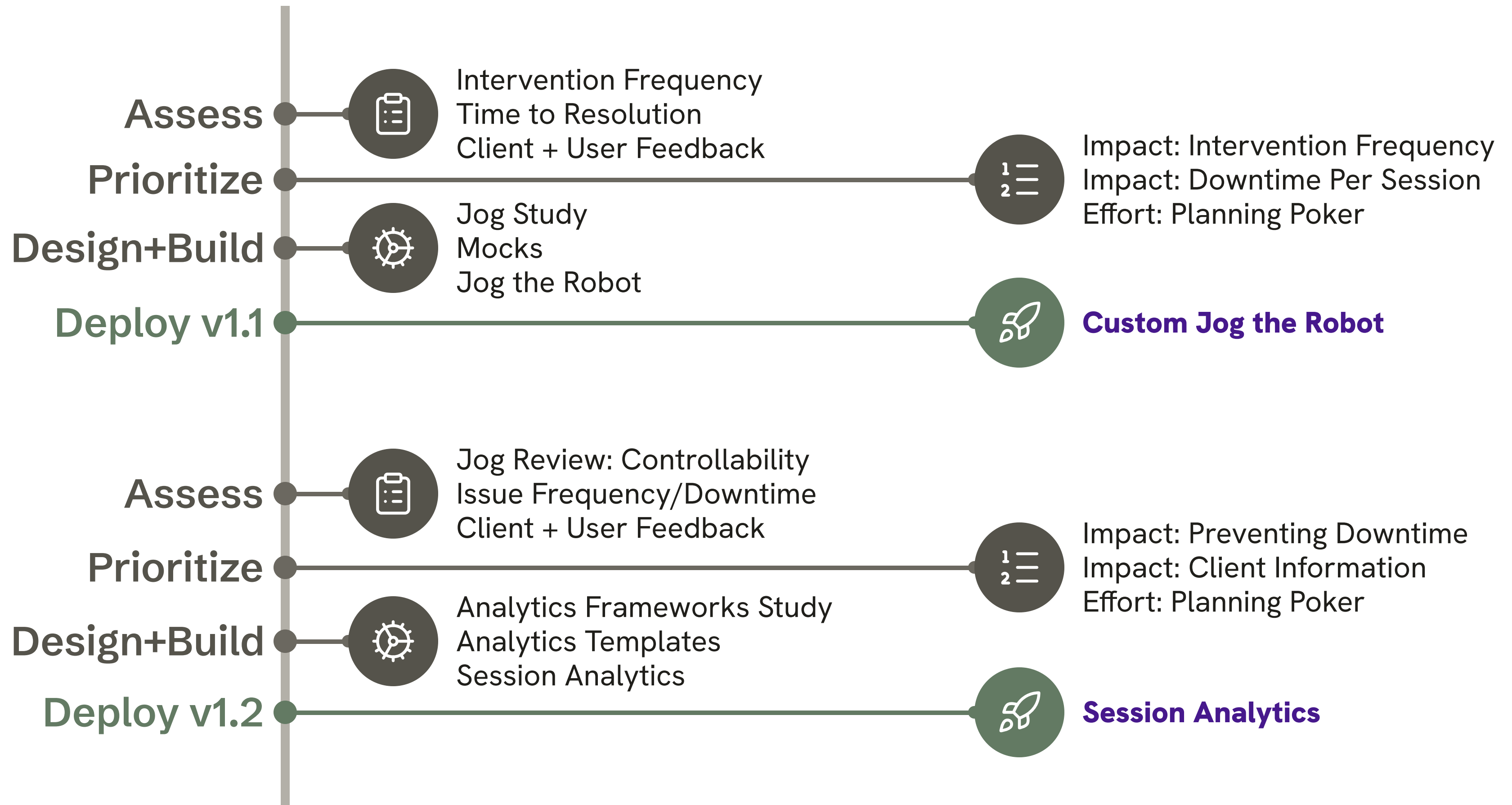
Class Intro

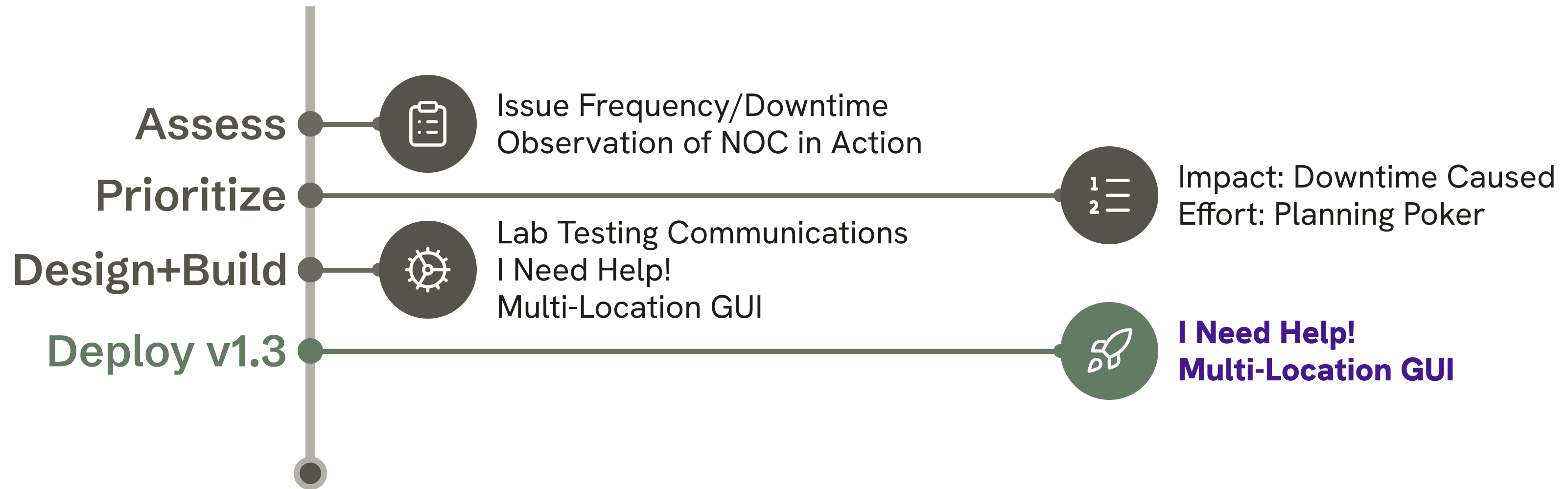
- Get real users

Real Timeline Excerpt: Network Operating Center

Class Intro







You will launch a real product with real users.

In teams, launched this semester,
pitched at Demo Day to guests.

What we build

- Products real users can sign up for this semester
- Web first. A native iOS app must launch on the App Store.
- B2B is fine if your team can get users onto it
- Bring your own idea or project. Talk to me about ownership.

What We're NOT Focusing On

- × Hardware
- × Medical diagnosis or treatment
- × Financial or legal advice
- × Anything with minors' data
- × Research and publishing
- × Deep theory
- B2B, kinda: only if your team can get users onto it

One 150-minute block every Friday

Class Intro

News segment

What changed this week in AI and startups.

Discussion

Talk the idea through together as a class.

Short talk

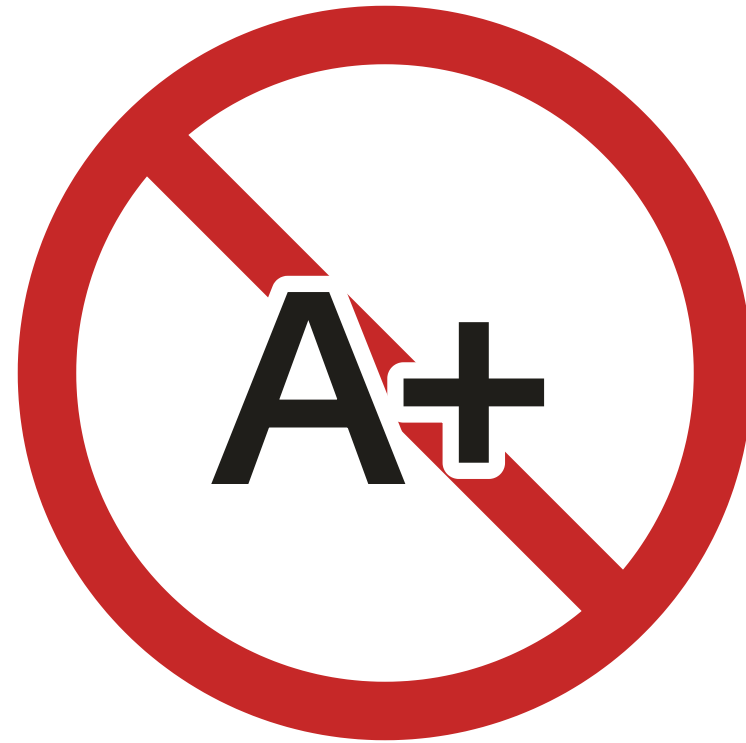
A new method or idea, kept brief.

Presentations

Teams show their work and get critique from the room.

Studio time

Try the method, build with your team, or meet with me.



This is not an **A+** course.

Your grade comes from Demo Day,
milestones, peer reviews, and real users.

Where your grade comes from

Class Intro

Component	What counts	Weight
Demo Day	Your pitch and working product	30%
Milestone submissions	On time, quality, shows learning	40%
Peer reviews	Your teammates rate your work	20%
User growth	Real users on your product	10%
Total		100%

Teamwork matters, and your team grades you

- Peer reviews are 20% of your grade.

Associated costs

Item	Cost
Books	None. There are no books to buy.
A top AI coding tool subscription	Enough for real development work
Domain name	Under \$30 a year
Hosting	About \$5 a month
Team ad budget	\$100 per team, \$25 each
Interview incentives	Optional, up to \$100 per team

Working in Public

Class Intro

- Everything you build here is not stealth and may be shared publicly.
- Previous IP remains yours, but you should document it.
- Columbia doesn't claim what you build. This isn't an incubator.
- Ownership: see next slide.
- This does NOT mean open sourcing your work.

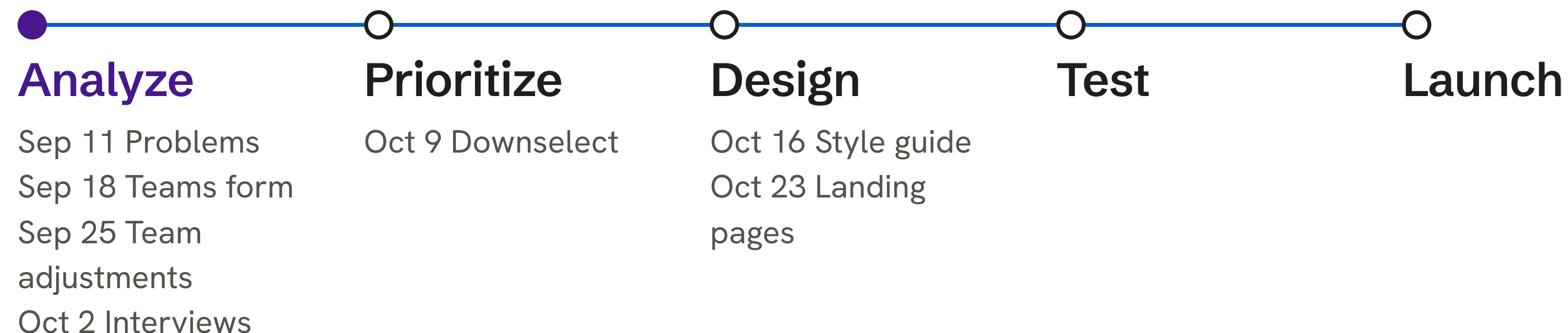
Ownership

Class Intro

- Previous IP should be documented and remains yours.
- Company ownership usually comes as stock with a one-year cliff. Less than a year, and you get none of it.
- This course is about three months, so assume no one owns it.
- At the end, whoever wants to take it can.
- If you think you'll want it, talk about it early. The code base is easy to split. The user base is tougher.

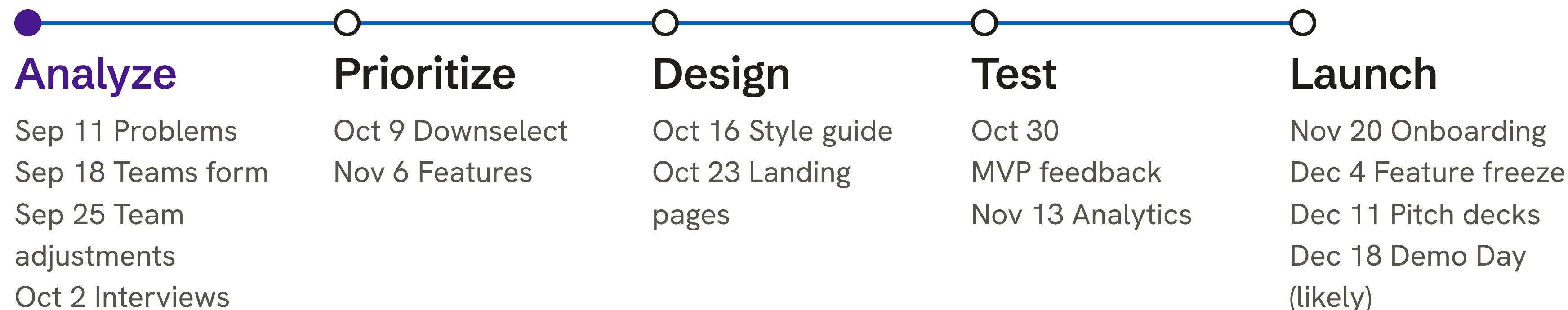
The semester, from problems to Demo Day

This schedule is a draft. Dates may change.



The semester, from problems to Demo Day

This schedule is a draft. Dates may change.

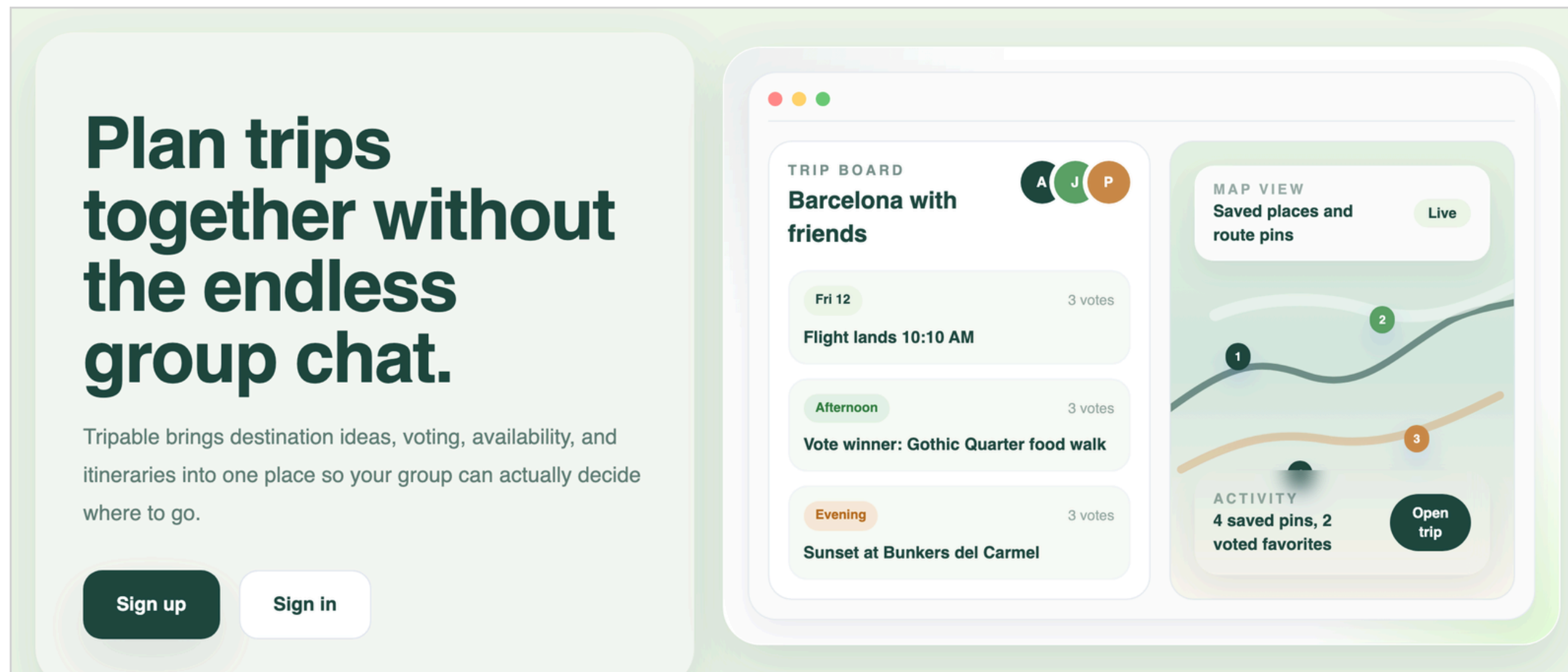


What students built last semester

Tripable

What students built last semester

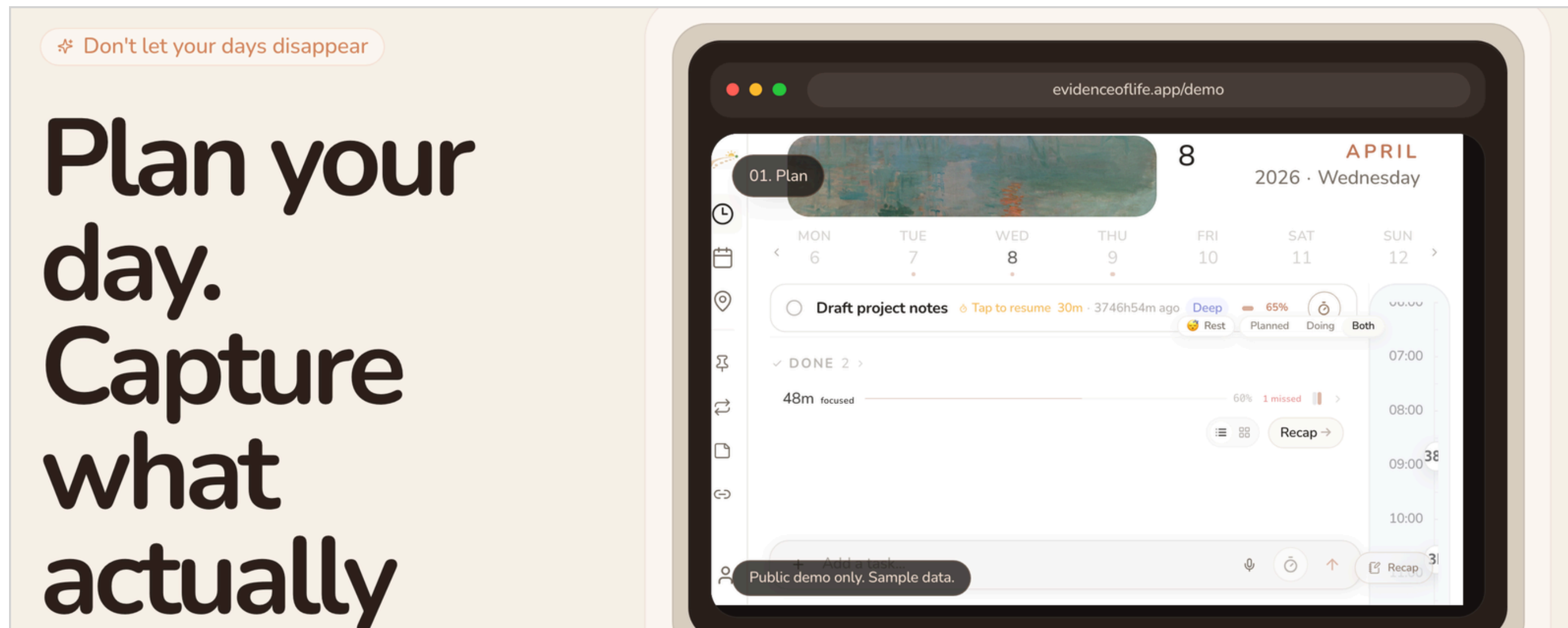
Group trip planning: votes, itinerary, and costs in one place.



Evidence of Life

What students built last semester

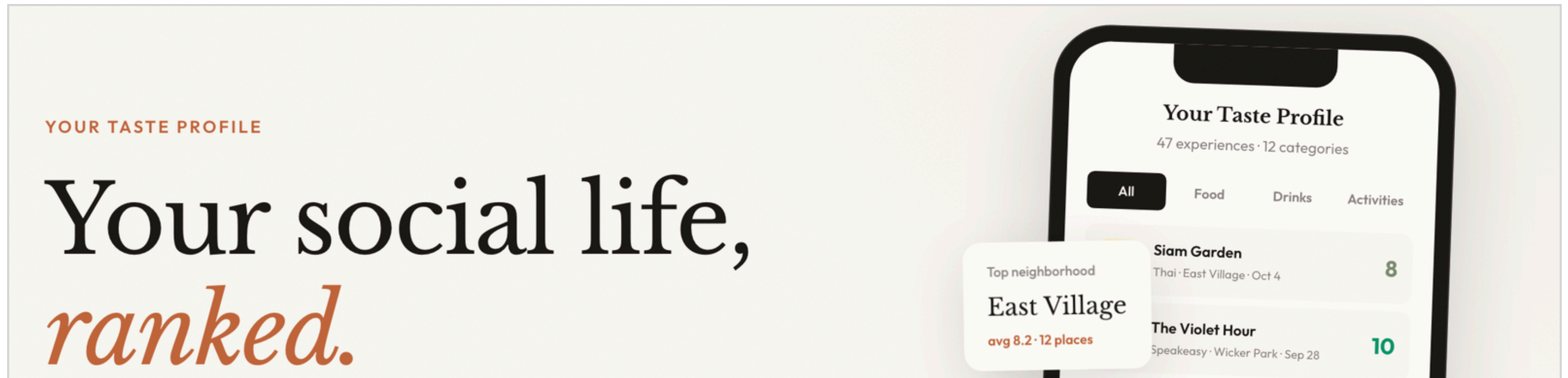
A private timeline that shows what actually happened,
not just what was planned.



Vouch

What students built last semester

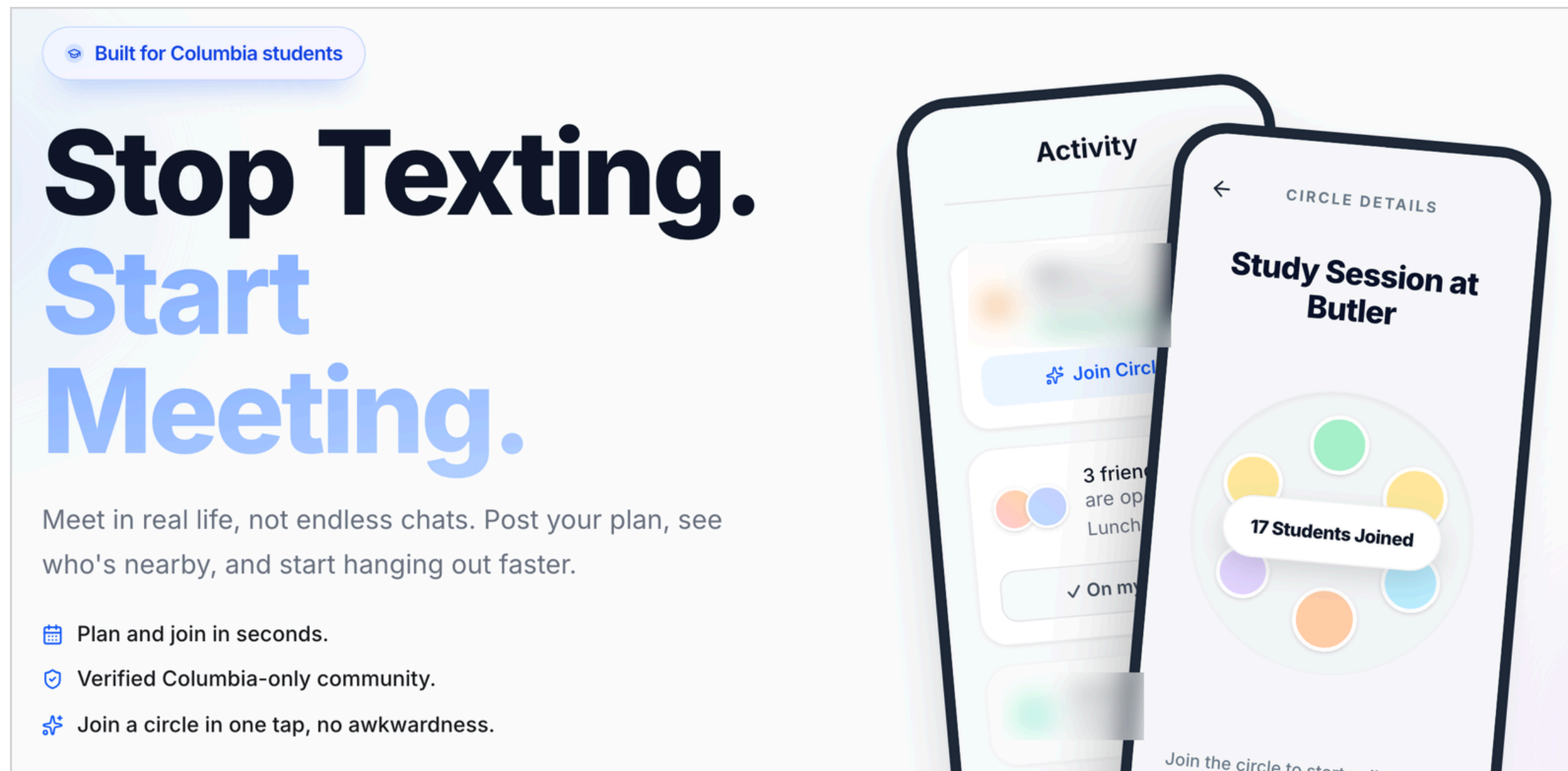
Ratings where your friends are the algorithm.



Circles

What students built last semester

Social coordination built for Columbia students.



QuestCity and Misfit.AI

What students built last semester

Stop Repeating the Same Date Night. Start Collecting Experiences.

Turn your city into an adventure game. Complete quests, discover hidden gems, and never run out of things to do—solo or together.

Get Early Access

3 Steps to More Adventures

Step 1: Pick a Quest

"Find 5 rooftop bars in Brooklyn" • "Hidden murals walking tour" • "Best tacos in a 2-mile radius"

QuestCity

Gamified outdoor exploration for friends and strangers.

One less decision every morning.

Wardrobe Planner looks at your calendar, checks the weather, and suggests exactly what to wear — using what you already own, so you show up looking effortless.

Connect Your Google Calendar — Start Free

No credit card required • \$1.99/mo after your free start • Cancel anytime

Misfit.AI

AI analyzes your wardrobe, calendar, and weather for wardrobe recommendations.

Logistics

Coming to class

Logistics

- Class is in person in Pupin 420. No remote attendance.
- No auditing.
- On the waitlist? Come today and on Sept 18.
- Sept 18 repeats today for anyone who joins late.

Class Position on AI

Logistics

Use AI for everything.

The AI you use will eventually come with a monetary cost.

Where things live

Logistics

Where	What's there
Courseworks	Syllabus, announcements, homework. COMSW4995_014_2026_3
Ed Discussion	edstem.org/us/courses/106430/discussion
Public repo	github.com/kenxle/columbia-startup-studio-fall-2026
Not added yet	Email me at krs2212@columbia.edu

Dec 18

Likely date for Demo Day

Likely Fri Dec 18, 12:00 to 3:00 PM, in the final exam slot, to be confirmed.

Nearest slot on the registrar's projected schedule

AI in the news

A question about the pace and stakes of frontier AI.

What does it mean to call for an AI slowdown?

Frontier AI leaders are debating how fast to build, and how to describe the stakes.

What is in the news

Anthropic's Dario Amodei has called for slower frontier development and more oversight. Other leaders agree in part; Meta's Mark Zuckerberg pushes back. Some invoke human extinction. Treat that as a claim to examine.

Discuss

- 1 Is this a safety argument?
- 2 Is this positioning?
- 3 What evidence is missing?

By the end of today

How the course runs

- 1 **Understand** what you tried in the voice homework.
- 2 **Compare** methods with other people in the room.
- 3 **Finalize** a team of 4 or 5.
- 4 **Start** a first divergent and convergent design cycle.

Did the *AI* write like *you*?

Homework discussion

Talk it through

Homework review

7:00

- 1 **What did you ask AI to write?** A post, article, news update, or something else.
- 2 **What did you give it?** Samples, rules, a profile, a reference, or a workflow.
- 3 **What worked?** Point to one sentence that felt like you.
- 4 **Where did it break?** Point to one sentence that did not.

What makes a voice system work?

Profiles, examples, rules, maintenance

Combine multiple techniques

Voice system

Few-shot examples

Real writing in the target genre.

Human profile

Patterns found in samples and reference points.

Contrastive rules

Do this, not that, and why.

Org profile

Structure, rhythm, and paragraph jobs.

What breaks

- × **Competing rules.** Rules that conflict cause confusion and the LLM has to decide which to follow.
- × **Larger contexts.** As the context fills, adherence tends to drop.
- × **The context contradicts the rule.** Broken examples teach the model the opposite behavior.
- × **Rewrites are usually different than first writes.** It may add rationale, a change log, or explanations you did not ask for.

Maintenance

Voice system

Every new model will need new tweaking.



Capture

Keep the good sample and the edit.



Compare

Look for a repeated move.



Promote

Turn it into a candidate rule.



Test

Try it on a fixed prompt set.



Retire

Drop rules that no longer fit.

Studio time

Speed dating is in service of finalizing teams.

Speed dating: answer three questions

Studio time

- 1 What is one project you're proud of?
- 2 What kind of user or problem space are you drawn to?
- 3 What would you like to get better at through this course?

Speed dating

Studio time

20:00

- 1 What is one project you're proud of?
- 2 What kind of user or problem space are you drawn to?
- 3 What would you like to get better at through this course?

Team constraints

Team formation

#	Constraint	What it means
1	4 or 5 people	A team is not complete with 3 people.
2	No more than 12 teams total	Finals are Demo Day, and we get 3 hours for the Finals period. This means we cannot support more than 12 teams in total.
3	You form teams yourselves	I'm not forming teams for you. This course requires non-stop teamwork and communication with people you do not know. Let's break the seal and get to it. You've got this.
4	Choose a working fit	Breadth of skills and reliable communication are good signals to look for

Finalize your team

Team formation

- 1 Find the people you want to work with.
- 2 Use the Ed Discussion thread to post what you would like to work on and find your team before class next week.
- 3 Make sure your team has 4 or 5 people.
- 4 Make sure the room has no more than 12 teams.
- 5 Choose one person to report your team name and members.

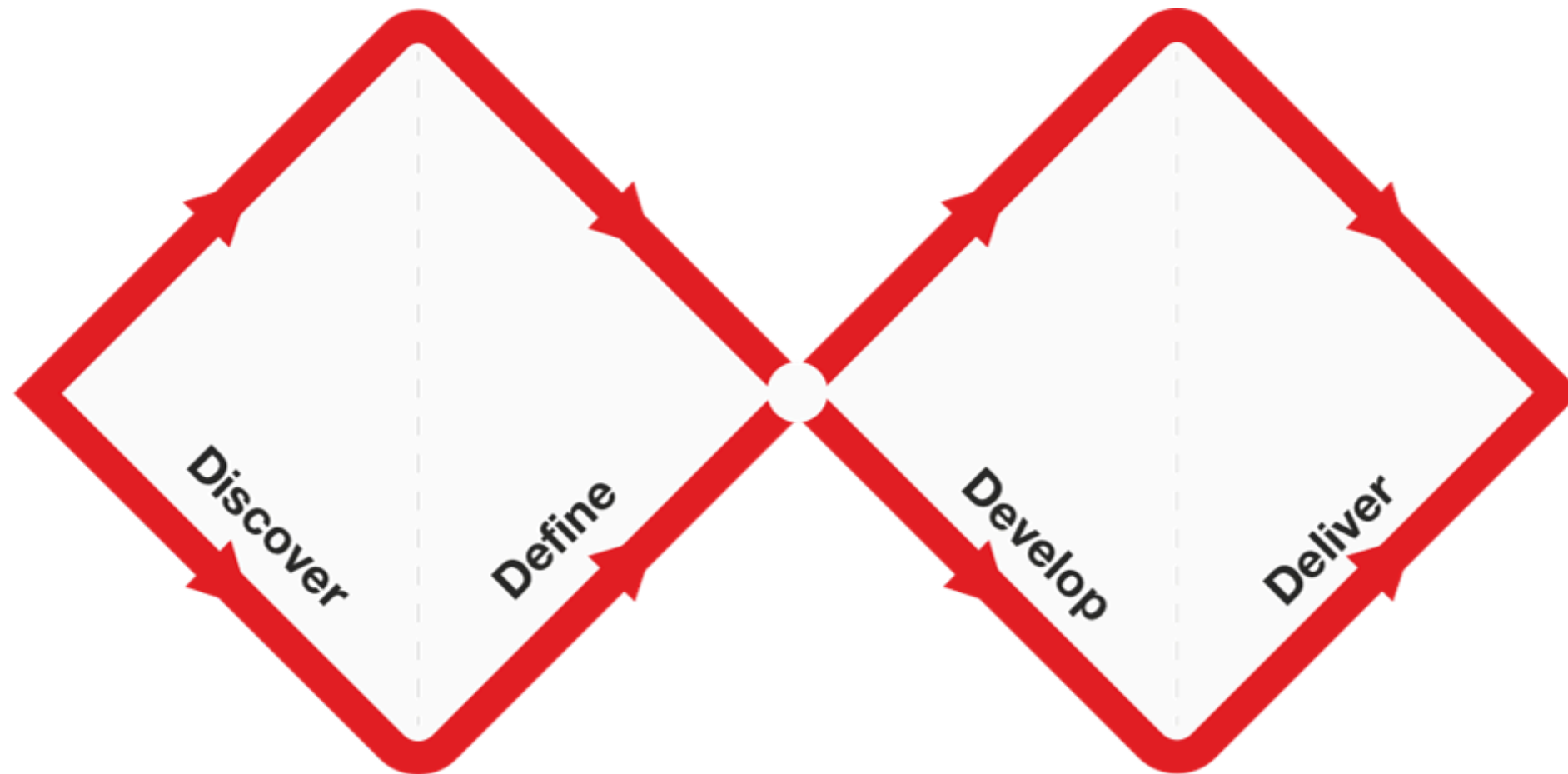
Design Thinking (w/ AI)

Teams are formed. The next job is to choose what deserves your attention.

The Double Diamond

Design thinking

There are a number of different frameworks for design thinking, but the double diamond is a popular and effective one.



Discover → Define → Develop → Deliver

Diverge and converge

Divergent

- Flesh out the idea space
- Make unexpected combinations
- Spark ideas and problems to explore

Convergent

- Remove the weaker problems
- Cut less effective ideas
- Narrow to what's worth pursuing

Diamond one gets the **right thing**. Diamond two gets the **thing right**.

Where AI helps

- Generating many variations
- Connecting distant concepts
- Recombination

Humans set direction. AI expands. Humans select.

Expand with AI, then choose 2-3

Team studio

20:00

- 1 Choose a broad theme connected to your team.
- 2 Each person writes 3 problems, users, or contexts on a shared FigJam board.
- 3 Run your list through AI to expand and connect ideas.
- 4 Cluster everything by pattern.
- 5 Pick your top 2-3 problem spaces to validate with users.

By Next Week

Team formation

Your team report

Team name

4 or 5 members

2-3 problem spaces to validate

- ✓ One person submits the team information.

See you **next Friday**

Bring a team, 2-3 problems that you want to validate.

Class 3 · Friday, September 25 · 1:10 PM · Pupin 420